

BONUS RESOURCE

The Automation Checklist

A step-by-step system for turning repetitive tasks into Copilot-powered workflows

- A decision framework: chat prompt, scheduled prompt, agent, or Power Automate flow
- The audit method for finding which of your tasks are actually worth automating
- Step-by-step builds for scheduled prompts, a custom agent and a triggered flow
- A pre-launch checklist and a maintenance rhythm so automations keep working

Current as of September 2026. Covers Scheduled Prompts, Agent Builder, Copilot Studio agents and Power Automate - the four levels of Copilot automation available inside Microsoft 365.

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1 The four levels of automation

Same word, four different tools - pick wrong and it either can't finish the job or costs more than it should

"Automate it with Copilot" means four different things depending on what you actually build. Picking the wrong level is the single biggest reason people abandon automation - either the tool was too heavy for the job, or too light to finish it.

Level 1 - Ask each time

WHAT IT IS	A prompt you type into the Copilot pane whenever you need it.
USE IT WHEN	Something you do rarely, or where every instance is different enough that a saved routine would not fit.

Level 2 - Scheduled prompt

WHAT IT IS	The same prompt, saved and set to run on a cadence: hourly, daily, weekly, monthly.
USE IT WHEN	A recurring information need with no decision attached - a briefing, a digest, a status pull.

Level 3 - Custom agent

WHAT IT IS	A purpose-built assistant with its own instructions, knowledge and, increasingly, its own schedule, built in Copilot Studio Agent Builder.
USE IT WHEN	A repeated job with real logic behind it - qualify this, draft that, check this against a rule set - that other people should be able to use too.

Level 4 - Power Automate flow

WHAT IT IS	A structured, triggered workflow: when X happens, do Y, then Z, across specific systems.
USE IT WHEN	A process with a defined trigger and a known sequence, especially one that touches multiple systems or must run exactly the same way every time.

The pattern underneath all four: Copilot Studio handles ambiguity - it understands a question asked differently each time. Power Automate handles determinism - it runs the same steps the same way, triggered by a defined event. Most automation failures come from using the ambiguity tool for a deterministic job, or the deterministic tool for a job that needed judgement.

2 Audit: what is worth automating

Fifteen minutes that stop you automating the wrong thing

Before you build anything, spend fifteen minutes finding out what actually deserves it. Most people automate the task that annoys them most that week, not the one costing them the most time overall.

1 List a week of repeats

For two working days, write down every task you do more than once that follows roughly the same steps. Do not filter yet - quantity beats judgement at this stage.

2 Score each on three things

Frequency (how often), Time (minutes per instance), Variability (does the input change meaningfully each time, or is it basically the same shape).

3 Multiply frequency by time

This is your annual-hours number. A five-minute task done daily costs more than an hour-long task done quarterly - the ranking usually surprises people.

4 Rule out the wrong candidates

High variability, high judgement, or high consequence of error (legal, financial, anything client-facing without review) are poor first automations. Start where being wrong is cheap to catch.

5 Pick one, not five

Automate the highest-scoring task that survived step 4. Ship it, use it for a week, then come back to this list for the next one.

HAVE COPILOT SCORE THE LIST FOR YOU

"Here is a list of tasks I do repeatedly: [paste your list with rough frequency and time each]. Score each for automation potential considering frequency, time cost and how much judgement is involved each time. Recommend which one to automate first and why."

3 Choose the right level

Answer in order - the first yes is where you build

Answer these in order. The first "yes" tells you where to build.

Does this need to run on its own, with no one asking?

No -> Level 1, ask each time. Yes -> keep going.

Is it one prompt against one source, on a schedule, with no branching logic?

Yes -> Level 2, scheduled prompt. No -> keep going.

Does it need its own knowledge, instructions, or a personality other people will reuse?

Yes -> Level 3, custom agent. No -> keep going.

Does it need to trigger on an event and touch a specific, structured system - a form, an inbox rule, a database, an approval?

Yes -> Level 4, Power Automate. Still unsure -> it is probably Level 3.

HOW THE LEVELS DIFFER IN PRACTICE

Trigger

Level 2: time only. Level 3: a chat message or a schedule. Level 4: an event - an email arrives, a form is submitted, a record changes, a timer fires.

Handles variation

Level 2: poorly - keep the prompt fixed. Level 3: well - that is its job. Level 4: not at all by default - build branches for every case you expect.

Who can use it

Level 2: just you. Level 3: shareable with a team once published. Level 4: runs for whoever it is built for, invisibly.

Failure mode

Level 2: a stale or generic answer. Level 3: a confidently wrong answer if the knowledge base is thin. Level 4: a hard stop, or a wrong action taken silently.

4 Build a scheduled prompt

The lightest level, and the one to try first

Available in Microsoft 365 Copilot Chat, Teams and Outlook. The lightest level of automation, and the one most people should try first.

1

Write the prompt as if running it fresh

Test it manually a couple of times first. If it needs editing every time you run it, it is not ready to be scheduled.

2

Hover the prompt and choose Schedule

In microsoft365.com/chat, Teams or Outlook, hover a prompt you have run and select "Schedule this prompt." You can also describe the cadence in plain language in the Work tab - "help me prepare for my day every Monday at 9am."

3

Set cadence and destination

Choose the frequency and where the result lands - a chat with yourself, a Teams channel, email or a OneNote page. Channel or shared chat if a team should see it; a private chat if it is just for you.

4

Confirm and let it run once before trusting it

Check the first automated run against what you expected before you stop checking manually.

PROMPTS WORTH SCHEDULING

"Every weekday at 7:30am, summarise my calendar, flag any meeting I have not prepared for, and list emails from the last 24 hours that need a reply."

"Every Monday at 9am, pull open action items assigned to me across my last five meetings and put them in priority order."

"On the first working day of the month, summarise last month's numbers from [source] against target and flag anything more than 10 per cent off."

"Every Friday at 4pm, draft my weekly status update from this week's emails and meetings, in three sections: shipped, blocked, next."

Scheduled prompts are on by default wherever your organisation allows Connected Experiences, and require a Microsoft 365 Copilot licence. Governance for this feature moved under the standard Microsoft 365 Connected Experiences policy in August 2026 - existing schedules were not affected, but if a scheduled prompt suddenly stops, that policy is the first place to check with an admin.

5 Build a custom agent

For a job with real logic behind it, that others might reuse

Agent Builder (in Copilot Studio, reachable from Microsoft 365 Copilot) is where you give Copilot a job description instead of a one-off instruction. Use it when a scheduled prompt is too rigid but a full Power Automate flow is more than the task needs.

- 1 Name the job, not the tool**
 "Meeting Prep Assistant" or "Client Onboarding Checker" - a name that describes the outcome, so anyone you share it with understands it in three words.
- 2 Write instructions like you are onboarding a new hire**
 State the goal, the tone, what it should always do, and what it should never do. Vague instructions produce vague agents - this is the highest-leverage step.
- 3 Attach knowledge**
 Point it at specific documents, a SharePoint site or a knowledge source relevant to the job - not your whole tenant. A narrow, well-chosen source beats a broad, noisy one.
- 4 Add starter prompts**
 Give it three or four example questions people can click instead of typing, especially if you will share it with a team.
- 5 Test with edge cases before you trust the happy path**
 Ask it the question it will get wrong first: missing information, an ambiguous request, a trick question. Fix the instructions, not just the one bad answer.
- 6 Publish, and schedule it if it should run on its own**
 Published agents can be shared with specific people or a team. Scheduled workflows for agents (hourly to yearly) are rolling out through 2026 - check availability in your tenant before you depend on it.

WRITE THE INSTRUCTIONS WITH COPILOT'S HELP

"Help me write clear instructions for a Copilot agent whose job is to [job]. Include: its goal, its tone, what information it should always ask for if missing, what it should refuse to do, and two examples of a good response."

An agent is only as good as what it is allowed to see and as narrow as its instructions make it. The most common failure is not a bad model - it is an agent given a vague brief and a knowledge base too broad to reason over well.

6 Build a triggered flow

For a process that must run the same way every time

Power Automate is for the jobs that must happen the same way, every time, set off by something actually occurring - not by a clock. This is the level with the most setup and the most payoff for a process that touches more than one system.

1 Name the trigger precisely

"A form is submitted", "an email arrives matching a subject pattern", "a row is added to this sheet", "a file is uploaded to this folder". If you cannot name the exact trigger, the process is not ready to automate yet.

2 Map the steps before you open Power Automate

On paper: trigger, then each action in order, then where it ends. Ask Copilot to help structure this in plain language first - the flow-building step goes faster once the logic is settled.

3 Build with the Copilot-assisted flow creator, or ask the Workflows Agent

Describe the flow in natural language and let Copilot draft the steps, or in Microsoft 365 Chat or Teams, @mention the Workflows Agent and describe the automation - it can build simple approval and notification flows without opening Power Automate directly.

4 Add the branches you can predict

What happens if a required field is blank? If the approver does not respond in three days? If the record already exists? Untested branches are where flows silently fail.

5 Test with real-shaped data, then watch the first live run

Run it against a copy or a test record first. Then let the first real trigger fire and check every step completed as expected before you stop watching.

DESCRIBE THE FLOW IN PLAIN LANGUAGE FIRST

"Whenever a new route plan is generated, ask for my approval before it goes out."

"When a form response comes in with a budget over 5,000, notify my manager and add the request to the approvals list."

"When an email arrives with an attachment from a client, save the attachment to the client's folder and post a note in the team channel."

"When a task in this list is marked complete, send a summary to the requester and archive the row."

Desktop flows that click through a specific screen layout have historically been the most fragile part of any automation - one interface change breaks the whole chain. Self-healing desktop automation, which adapts to interface changes at runtime instead of relying on fixed screen positions, is rolling out through 2026 and is worth checking for in your tenant before you build anything screen-dependent.

7 Pre-launch checklist

Run through this before anything goes live

Run through this before anything goes live, especially anything you plan to share.

Check	Ask yourself
Scope	Does it do one job well, rather than several jobs adequately? Split it if not.
Failure visibility	If it fails silently, will you find out before someone downstream does?
Owner	If you share this with a team, who fixes it when it breaks? Write their name down now, not when it breaks.
Data access	Does it see only what it needs? A narrower knowledge source or permission set fails safer than a broad one.
Review point	For anything financial, legal, or client-facing: is a human checking the output before it goes anywhere external? Automate the draft, not the send, until you trust it.
Off switch	Do you know how to pause or delete this in under a minute? Find the control before you need it under pressure.

8 Keep it running

Set and check on a schedule, not set and forget

Automation is not "set and forget" - it is "set and check on a schedule of your choosing, instead of constantly." A short rhythm keeps small breaks from becoming trust-destroying ones.

When	What to do
Weekly, first month	Skim every output. This is where you catch a prompt that was almost right but not quite, before it becomes a habit to distrust.
Monthly, after that	Spot-check outputs against source data. Confirm the automation still points at the right people, sheet, or channel - these drift more often than the logic breaks.
On any source change	A renamed column, a moved file, a changed approval chain - re-test immediately. These are the most common real-world failure, not the AI reasoning itself.
Quarterly	Ask whether this automation still earns its place, and whether the task it does has changed enough to need a rewrite rather than a patch.

HAVE COPILOT SPOT THE DRIFT

"Here is what this automation is supposed to produce: [description]. Here is its most recent output: [paste]. Does the output match the intent? Flag anything that looks off, stale, or like it is quietly drifting from what I originally asked for."

9 Nine automations to steal

Proven starting points, ordered by how often they pay off first

Proven starting points, ordered by how commonly they pay off first.

Morning briefing	Level 2	Calendar, unread priority emails and today's open action items, delivered before you sit down.
Weekly status draft	Level 2	Pulls the week's activity into a shipped / blocked / next draft you edit rather than write from scratch.
Meeting-to-task pipeline	Level 2 + manual step	Scheduled recap-to-action prompt after your recurring meetings, paired with the action-item quality check from the Teams pack.
Order or ticket status lookup	Level 3	A shared agent that answers "what's the status of order X" by checking your system, so the question stops landing in your inbox.
Client onboarding checker	Level 3	Answers new-client questions from your onboarding documentation, consistently, at any hour.
Approval routing	Level 4	A form or record over a threshold automatically notifies the right approver and logs the decision.
Inbox-to-folder filing	Level 4	Attachments from a specific sender or subject line are saved and the team is notified, without anyone dragging a file.
New-record notification	Level 4	A row added to a tracking sheet or a new form response posts a summary to the relevant channel.
Monthly numbers digest	Level 2	First-of-month scheduled prompt comparing the latest figures to target and flagging anything off by more than a set threshold.

QUICK REFERENCE

The Automation Checklist

PICK THE LEVEL

- Rare or always different -> ask each time
- Same prompt, on a clock, no branching -> scheduled prompt
- Needs its own knowledge or judgement, or others will use it -> custom agent
- Triggered by an event, touches specific systems -> Power Automate

BEFORE YOU BUILD

- Frequency x time = the number that matters, not how annoying it feels this week
- Rule out high-variability, high-judgement, high-consequence tasks as a first automation
- Automate the draft, not the send, until you trust the output

BEFORE YOU LAUNCH

- One job, not several
- A named owner if anyone else will use it
- Narrowest data access that still works
- A human review point for anything external or financial
- You know how to pause it in under a minute

KEEP IT ALIVE

- Skim every output for the first month
- Spot-check monthly after that
- Re-test immediately on any source or system change
- Ask quarterly whether it still earns its place

The goal was never to automate everything. It was to stop personally doing the parts of your work that do not need a person - so the parts that do get more of your attention, not less.